

The Tell-tale SIGNS



FORGETTING simple chores—cooking, making tea, unlocking doors, dial a phone and so on.

DROPPING words, using wrong ones, repeating sentences, losing speech and language skills.



LOSING track of time—day and night, months and years. Notion of space gets warped, too.

STRUGGLING to think coherently, take decisions, balance cheque books or count money.



MISPLACING objects, losing keys, money and keeping things in inappropriate places.

FAILING to remember names, faces, daily chores, appointments. Slipping job performance.

Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS), Bangalore. "But in Alzheimer's, there is an overall shrinkage of brain tissue, very different from normal ageing," he says. But researchers still don't understand why Alzheimer's is selective in the way it attacks the brain. It begins in the memory areas—the hippocampus, which is critical to memory—and spreads slowly to other parts over a period of two to three years. "We really don't know why a disease would ravage certain areas of the brain but leave vision and hearing completely untouched," says Verghese. In the early stage, when the hippocampus degenerates, short-term memory is affected. But as it spreads through the cerebral cortex (the outer layer of the brain), the sense of judgement declines and emotional outbursts occur along with language impairment. Death of more nerve cells lead to further changes in behaviour—agitation and the tendency to wander off. In the final stages, the patient loses the ability to recognise their closest kins, muscle control, bodily functions and needs constant care.

And it's a world of suffering—for both the patient and the caregiver. Vinod Chugh of Delhi got his first symptoms right after retirement. His mood swings were put down to depression. It took two years of visits and battles before he finally got a diagnosis. Meantime, his personality turned abusive. Then he lost his sense of night and day. His wife would put him to bed; he would wake up and walk around the house. The process would be repeated 20 to 30 times at night. Every night. Not just that. Suddenly, he would go missing and she would get phone calls from the police. He couldn't recognise people who came into the house and was frightened because he did not understand what was happening to him. Every act of care made him suspicious and scared him even more. His wife bore it all, but at a high price. For her, life became a little bubble—her home, her patient and nothing else.

What's worse is that one family member struck by the disorder can

mean several collateral victims, with heavy tolls on family life and resources. When 60-something Rama Ramachandraiah of Bangalore was diagnosed with Alzheimer's, her family had to cope as much with the financial as the medical and emotional effects of the neurological disorder. "The drugs would cost about Rs 2,500 a month," says her daughter, "Then there are the tests. An MRI costs Rs 7,000 and a CT scan about Rs 2,000 and until it was diagnosed, we had about four of each done." Then there were the regular tests—blood sugar, TSH—which cost about Rs 1,200 every two months. Around Rs 7,500 went to the nurse, with the agency asking for Rs 3,000 every six months to renew the contract. "In addition, it is said that an Alzheimer's patient falls at least four times a year," she says. "When my mother fell and broke an arm, we spent Rs 58,000 for the wrist surgery and 18 hours in hospital."

A cure for dementia is still a distant dream. But there's some action behind the scenes that raises new hope. Silently and largely out of sight, memory clinics are popping up in city after city, across the country—Kochi to Chandigarh, Thane to Siliguri—to address a crying need: a desperate shortage of affordable and qualified caregivers. "Memory clinics help screening for dementia, counsel family members, help patients recall past events, provide techniques to recall things by giving them memory cards among other things," says Kausik Majumdar, a UK-trained dementia specialist who now runs the service at the National Neurosciences Centre in Kolkata. The Government has not gone out of its way to help these clinics. India Inc has not offered a helping hand. Yet, as some of the missing pieces start falling in place in the dementia jigsaw puzzle, a new legitimacy is being forged for a clutch of people who have always been discussed in hushed tones by family members and kept out of sight as an embarrassment. ■